

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN LESOTHO

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide begins with an honest truth that makes it different: sometimes a project cannot be stopped — and Lesotho's most famous fight is the proof, and the model for what you can still win when stopping is impossible. It is built around Lesotho's distinctive contribution — exposing and criminally prosecuting a mega-project's corruption, pressing the financiers to debar the corrupt, and winning the compensation, resettlement, and rights the affected are owed — and names each tool in plain words.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

The **Lesotho Highlands Water Project** — a chain of five dams and two hundred kilometres of tunnels through the Maluti Mountains, built under a **1986 treaty** to sell water to South Africa's industrial heartland and backed by the **World Bank** — could not be stopped. The highland communities in its path could not halt a scheme desired by a far more powerful neighbour and their own government, and they were displaced. But Lesotho did something no developing country had ever done. It **exposed and criminally prosecuted the corruption behind the project** — convicting the project's own chief executive of taking bribes, and then convicting the great multinational firms that had paid them: a Canadian company, a German one, a French one, an Italian one — and pressing the **World Bank to debar** the worst of them. A tiny, poor kingdom put the world's construction giants in the dock and won. And the affected communities, though they could not stop the dams, fought on for the compensation, the resettlement, and the rights they were owed.

When the Lesotho Highlands Water Project could not be stopped, Lesotho did something no developing country had done — it shifted the fight to accountability and to terms, and the tools it used are distinctive. The **courts** can prosecute the corruption behind a project, as they did the project's chief executive and the foreign firms that had bribed him. The **financiers** (the World Bank and others) can be pressed to **debar** corrupt contractors. The **compensation, resettlement, and rights** of the affected can be fought for and secured; lawful advocacy, litigation, and prosecution are the tools. And **international attention** and **anti-corruption cooperation** amplify it all. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The dams **were built**; the highland communities **were displaced**; the compensation has often been **inadequate and delayed**, and the fight for it continues. Accountability, however historic, **does not restore** a flooded valley or a lost livelihood. And Lesotho is small, poor, and bound to a **treaty with South Africa** it had little power to refuse. So aim, where a project cannot be stopped, to make the corruption pay and the affected people whole — the accountability and terms that are Lesotho's hard-won contribution.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A mega-project may be unstoppable, but its corruption and its terms are not beyond reach, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Lesotho fight turns, where stopping is possible, on the usual levers; and where it is not, on **exposing and prosecuting the corruption**; on pressing the **financiers to debar** the corrupt; and on winning the **compensation, resettlement, and rights** the affected are owed. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and accountability, when a project can't be stopped, is Lesotho's distinctive one. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend months — or years — on this, work out your real situation:

- **If the project can be stopped, use the usual levers** — the courts, the assessment, the community, the financier, mobilisation.
- **If it cannot be stopped — a treaty, a powerful neighbour, foreign money — shift to accountability and terms** — that is Lesotho's hard-won lesson and model.
- **If there is corruption behind it, expose and prosecute it** — Lesotho convicted its own official and the foreign giants who bribed him.
- **If communities are displaced, fight for compensation, resettlement, and rights** — the dams were built, but the fight for the affected people's due goes on.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **be honest about whether a project can be stopped**, and **when it cannot, shift the fight to accountability and terms — exposing the corruption, debarring the corrupt, and winning the affected their due**. That is Lesotho's distinctive contribution to the world.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and where it can still be held to account.

Who Actually Decides

A mega-project like the Highlands scheme is driven by a **treaty**, a **powerful neighbour** (South Africa), the **government**, and **foreign money** (the World Bank) — a combination a small kingdom cannot easily refuse. But the **courts** can prosecute the **corruption** behind it; the **financiers** can be pressed to **debar** the corrupt; and the **compensation, resettlement, and rights** of the affected can be fought for. Know which of these you can reach — accountability and terms are Lesotho's distinctive reach, when stopping is not.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The treaty and the money. The project is bound by treaty and foreign finance. *Your opening, if it cannot be stopped:* shift to accountability and terms.

The corruption. *Your opening — Lesotho's iconic one:* expose and prosecute the corruption behind the project, as Lesotho did its chief executive and the foreign firms.

The financiers. *Your opening:* press the World Bank and other financiers to **debar** the corrupt contractors.

The compensation and rights. *Your opening:* fight for the **compensation, resettlement, and rights** the displaced are owed.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's building it and who paid whom** — the contractors, the officials, the bribes — because the corruption is Lesotho's iconic lever. **Who finances it** — the World Bank and others, who can debar the corrupt. **What the affected are owed** — the compensation, resettlement, and rights, because that is what can still be won when the dam cannot be stopped.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **courts** can prosecute the corruption. The **financiers** (the World Bank) can debar the corrupt. The **compensation and resettlement** frameworks owe the affected their due. **International anti-corruption cooperation** and attention amplify it. And Lesotho's **affected communities, auditors, prosecutors, civil society, and international allies** are the forces that reach furthest — the coalition that put the world's construction giants in the dock.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises, and some projects here cannot be stopped. What most moves them: whether stopping is realistic, whether the corruption can be proven, and whether the financiers and courts will act.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Stop the project (if realistic)	10–35%	months–years	mod	A stoppable project halted
Expose the corruption	30–55%	months–years	low	The corruption brought to light
Prosecute the corruption (courts)	30–55%	years	mod	Officials and firms convicted (Lesotho)
Press financiers to debar the corrupt	30–55%	months–years	low	Corrupt contractors debarred
Win compensation / resettlement / rights	25–50%	years	low–mod	The affected made more whole
International anti-corruption cooperation	30–55%	years	low	Cross-border evidence and pressure
Everything together (accountability + terms)	35–60%	years	mod	Corruption punished; the affected's due won
Refusing an unstoppable treaty project	5–15%	—	—	Usually not realistic — shift to terms

The levers that move the needle most are **exposing and prosecuting the corruption** and pressing the **financiers to debar** the corrupt, alongside winning **compensation, resettlement, and rights**. Lesotho shows the ceiling (a poor kingdom convicting the world's construction giants and pressing the World Bank to debar them) and the honest floor (the dams were built, the communities displaced, and the compensation inadequate and delayed). So aim for corruption exposed and prosecuted, the corrupt debarred, and the affected's due won.

On cost: exposing corruption, pressing financiers, and fighting for compensation cost mainly organised effort and evidence; prosecution is carried by the state's courts and prosecutors. The great strength is the accountability model — holding a mega-project's corruption criminally to account; the great requirement is the honesty to shift to accountability and terms when a project cannot be stopped.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak, and sometimes unrealistic. Being specific — this bribe, this corrupt contractor, this compensation owed — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. Can it be stopped — honestly? Is it bound by a **treaty, a powerful neighbour, and foreign money** (likely unstoppable — shift to accountability and terms), or is it a stoppable project (use the usual levers)?

2. Who's building it, and is there corruption? Name the **contractors and officials**, and look for the **corruption** behind it — the bribes, the tainted contracts — because that is Lesotho's iconic lever.

3. Who finances it? The **World Bank and other financiers**, who can be pressed to **debar** corrupt contractors.

4. Who is displaced, and what are they owed? The **affected communities**, and the **compensation, resettlement, and rights** they deserve — what can still be won.

5. Who's your coalition? The **affected communities, auditors, prosecutors, civil society, and international anti-corruption allies**. Lesotho joined all of these to convict the giants.

What this looks like in real life. A treaty-bound, foreign-financed mega-dam will displace highland communities and cannot realistically be refused, and corruption taints its contracts. The five questions yield: an unstoppable project (shift to accountability and terms); contractors and officials to prosecute; financiers to press for debarment; displaced communities owed compensation; and a coalition of auditors, prosecutors, and international allies. That's the Lesotho pattern — expose and prosecute the corruption, debar the corrupt, and win the affected their due.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can hold a mega-project to account and one that can't is proof — of the corruption and of what's owed. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the corruption. The heart of it: document the **corruption behind the project** — the bribes, the tainted contracts, the officials and firms involved — with the auditors' and prosecutors' rigour that convicted Lesotho's chief executive and the foreign giants. This is the iconic evidence.

Layer two: the harm and what's owed. Document the **displacement and harm** to the affected communities, and the **compensation, resettlement, and rights** they are owed but have not received — the ground of the fight for terms.

Layer three: the financier and international map. Trace the **financiers** (the World Bank and others) who can debar the corrupt, and the **international anti-corruption cooperation** that can reach the foreign firms' home countries. Walking into the courts, the financiers, the compensation frameworks, or the world with the documented corruption and the documented harm is what holds a mega-project to account.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The corruption** — the bribes, the tainted contracts, the officials and firms — documented with rigour.
- **The displacement and harm** — with testimony from the affected communities.
- **What's owed** — the compensation, resettlement, and rights not received.
- **The financier map** — the World Bank and others, who can debar the corrupt.
- **The international anti-corruption links** — reaching the foreign firms' home countries.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a coalition of the affected, the auditors and prosecutors, and international allies gives you the power that convicted the giants. Build in four moves.

Root it in the affected communities. The displaced highland communities are the human heart of the fight — for their compensation, resettlement, and rights. Root the effort there, honouring what they lost.

Enlist the auditors and prosecutors. Lesotho's accountability model began with **auditing its own authority and prosecuting its own official** — then the foreign firms. Enlist the auditors, prosecutors, and lawyers who can build a criminal case rigorous enough to convict.

Reach the financiers and international allies. Press the **financiers** (the World Bank) to **debar** the corrupt, and enlist **international anti-corruption cooperation** to reach the foreign firms and their home countries — the reach that made Lesotho's convictions stick.

Build to last, and fight for terms. These fights run for years, and the fight for compensation continues still. Build clear roles, a secure archive, a way to decide together, and the endurance to prosecute the corruption and win the affected their due over the long haul.

STEP 4: ACCOUNTABILITY, THE FINANCIERS & THE AFFECTED'S DUE

Lesotho's sharpest levers, when a project cannot be stopped, are accountability and terms.

Exposing and Prosecuting the Corruption — the Iconic Lever

Lesotho's distinctive contribution: **expose and criminally prosecute the corruption** behind a mega-project. Lesotho audited its own authority, convicted its own chief executive of taking bribes, and then convicted the foreign firms that paid them — a Canadian, a German, a French, and an Italian company. Build the rigorous case that holds the corruption criminally to account.

Pressing the Financiers to Debar

Press the **financiers** — the **World Bank** and others — to **debar** the corrupt contractors, as Lesotho did with the worst offenders. Debarment reaches a firm's ability to win future contracts worldwide, a powerful sanction.

Winning the Affected's Due

Where the project cannot be stopped and communities are displaced, fight for the **compensation, resettlement, and rights** they are owed — which have too often been inadequate and delayed. Accountability does not restore a flooded valley, but it can make the affected more whole.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: this accountability model is historic and real, but the dams were built, the communities displaced, the compensation inadequate and delayed, and a treaty-bound project cannot easily be stopped. So use the levers — exposing and prosecuting the corruption, debarring the corrupt, and winning the affected's due — be honest about what cannot be stopped, and count corruption punished, the corrupt debarred, and the affected's due won as real wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Corruption becomes a criminal case. Not "the project is unfair" but *"the project's chief executive took bribes from these named foreign firms — and both can be convicted,"* as Lesotho proved.

A corrupt firm becomes a debarment case. *"This contractor bribed its way to the contract — the financiers should debar it worldwide."*

Displacement becomes a claim for terms. *"The dam was built and we were displaced — the compensation, resettlement, and rights we are owed have not been paid."*

An unstoppable project becomes an accountability fight. *"We could not stop the dam — but we can make its corruption pay and win our people their due."*

Match it to the venue: the corruption to the courts; the corrupt firm to the financiers' debarment; the displacement to the compensation and resettlement frameworks; the whole to international anti-corruption cooperation and the world's attention.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Lesotho, international attention is a real lever — a poor kingdom convicting the world's construction giants was a global story, and anti-corruption campaigners study it still — and it reaches the foreign firms' home countries and the financiers. International cooperation makes the media front reach far.

Lead with the corruption and the displaced, not procedure. Not "the contracting was flawed" but "a tiny kingdom put the world's dam-builders in the dock for bribery — and its displaced communities are still owed their due." Use your strongest material: the documented corruption, the convictions, and the affected communities.

Work several audiences at once. Lesotho's press and public build the accountability case; international attention reaches the foreign firms' home countries and the financiers, where debarment and reputation bite. Make it easy: clear summaries of the corruption, the convictions, and the harm.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — a corruption case must be rigorous and exact, or it collapses. And centre the affected communities, whose due is the human heart of the fight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Reporting the corruption (to auditors / prosecutors).

Subject: Corruption in [project] — [specifics].

"We, [group], have documented apparent corruption in [project]: [the bribes, the tainted contracts, the officials and firms]. We ask the auditors and prosecutors to investigate, as in the Highlands case. [Attach evidence.]"

8B — Pressing the financiers to debar.

Subject: Debar the corrupt contractors — [project].

"We ask [the World Bank / financier] to debar the contractors who bribed their way into [project]: [specifics], as was done in the Lesotho Highlands Water Project. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — Fighting for compensation / resettlement (to the authority).

Subject: Compensation and resettlement owed — [community].

"We, the displaced community of [place], are owed compensation, resettlement, and rights not yet paid: [specifics]. We ask that our due be met. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — To a lawyer (prosecution / claim).

Subject: Corruption case / compensation claim — [project].

"Our community faces [corruption in [project] / displacement and unpaid compensation], and we've gathered [the evidence]. We ask your advice on a prosecution or claim. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8E — To international anti-corruption allies.

Subject: Holding [project]'s foreign contractors to account.

"[Project]'s foreign contractors [named] appear to have paid bribes. We ask your help to reach their home countries and the financiers, as in the Lesotho case. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8F — To the foreign contractor / firm.

Subject: Corruption and reputational risk — [project].

"We are the community affected by [project]. Evidence of corruption in its contracting [specifics] faces prosecution, debarment, and international attention, as in the Highlands case. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the (international) press.

Subject: Corruption in a mega-dam — and communities still owed their due.

"[Project]'s contracting was tainted by corruption, and its displaced communities are owed compensation not yet paid. We can provide the documented corruption and the harm. [Contact.]"

8H — Uniting the affected communities.

Subject: We couldn't stop the dam — let's win our due and make the corruption pay.

"The dam was built and we were displaced, but Lesotho once convicted the world's giants for their bribes and pressed the Bank to debar them. Let's expose the corruption and win the compensation and rights we are owed. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Be honest about whether the project can be stopped — if not, shift to accountability and terms.**
2. **Document the corruption behind it — the bribes, the tainted contracts (8A).**
3. **Report it to the auditors and prosecutors, as Lesotho did (8A/8D).**
4. **Press the financiers to debar the corrupt contractors (8B).**
5. **Fight for the compensation, resettlement, and rights the affected are owed (8C).**
6. **Reach international anti-corruption allies and the press (8E/8G).**

Even lean, those six hold a mega-project's corruption to account and fight for the affected's due — the Lesotho template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Lesotho's field is tilted by a treaty with a powerful neighbour, so plan for it.

When a project cannot be stopped. Be honest — a treaty-bound, foreign-financed mega-project desired by a powerful neighbour usually cannot be refused. Shift the fight to accountability and terms, which is Lesotho's hard-won lesson.

When there is corruption behind it. That is Lesotho's iconic opening. Expose and prosecute it rigorously, and press the financiers to debar the corrupt — a poor kingdom did exactly this to the world's giants.

When the affected are displaced. Fight for the compensation, resettlement, and rights they are owed, which have too often been inadequate and delayed — and keep fighting, because that fight continues.

When the asymmetry is stark. A small country tied to a powerful neighbour cannot match its power, but it can hold the corruption to account and win terms — the reach that international anti-corruption cooperation and the financiers provide.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Corruption is not a side issue in Lesotho's story — it is the central one, and holding it to account is Lesotho's gift to the world.

How to spot it. Bribes to officials for contracts; tainted procurement; foreign firms buying their way in; benefits to the connected while communities are displaced and underpaid.

Who's supposed to guard against it. Lesotho's **auditors and prosecutors** and the **courts** exposed and convicted the corruption in the Highlands case. The **financiers** (the World Bank) can debar the corrupt. **International anti-corruption cooperation** reaches the foreign firms' home countries. And Lesotho's **civil society and international allies** carry the accountability model.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — the bribes, the contracts, who paid whom — with the rigour a criminal case demands, and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the auditors, prosecutors, the courts, the financiers, and international anti-corruption bodies rather than making accusations you can't back. This rigour is exactly what made Lesotho's convictions stick.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The documented corruption and harm build your case; the accountability model aims it; the affected communities, auditors, and prosecutors are the muscle; the courts, the financiers, and international cooperation press it; the world's attention reaches the foreign firms. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and these fights run for years.

Early on (weeks 1–8): be honest about whether the project can be stopped; document the corruption and the harm; enlist the auditors, prosecutors, and affected communities.

In the thick of it (months–years): prosecute the corruption; press the financiers to debar the corrupt; fight for compensation, resettlement, and rights; reach international allies.

The long haul (years): carry the prosecutions and the compensation fight; keep the coalition and the evidence ready; hold the line for corruption exposed and prosecuted, the corrupt debarred, and the affected's due won.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Fighting a destructive project in Lesotho means, first, an honest reckoning: sometimes a project cannot be stopped — but even then, much can be won. Hold both truths. Lesotho's distinctive power is historic and real: when a project is driven by a treaty, a powerful neighbour, and foreign money and cannot be stopped, the fight shifts to accountability and terms — exposing and prosecuting the corruption behind it, pressing the financiers to debar the corrupt, and winning the compensation, resettlement, and rights the affected deserve. A tiny mountain kingdom put the world's construction giants in the dock and won. And the constraints are real: the dams were built, the highland communities displaced, the compensation inadequate and delayed, and a treaty with a far more powerful neighbour is not easily unmade.

Here's the discipline that wins what can be won. Be honest, first, about whether a project can be stopped: if it is bound by a treaty, a powerful neighbour, and foreign money, it likely cannot, and the fight must shift to accountability and terms. Then document the corruption behind it with the rigour a criminal case demands, and prosecute it — Lesotho audited its own authority, convicted its own chief executive, and then convicted the foreign firms that bribed him. Press the financiers, the World Bank among them, to debar the corrupt contractors worldwide. And fight, for as long as it takes, for the compensation, resettlement, and rights the displaced are owed. Count corruption exposed and prosecuted, the corrupt debarred, and the affected's due won as real wins — for accountability does not restore a flooded valley, but it can make the corruption pay and the people more whole. That is Lesotho's gift to the world: not that every project can be stopped, but that even the unstoppable can be held to account. So can you.